

Theological Standards (Full Excerpts)

By Westminster Divines

Psalm 23

The Lord is my shepherd; I shall not want. He maketh me to lie down in green pastures: he leadeth me beside the still waters. He restoreth my soul: he leadeth me in the paths of righteousness for his name's sake. Yea, though I walk through the valley of the shadow of death, I will fear no evil: for thou art with me; thy rod and thy staff they comfort me. Thou preparest a table before me in the presence of mine enemies: thou anointest my head with oil; my cup runneth over. Surely goodness and mercy shall follow me all the days of my life: and I will dwell in the house of the Lord for ever. This psalm, attributed to King David, is one of the most beloved passages in the Bible. It speaks of the intimate relationship between God and His people, using the metaphor of a shepherd and his sheep. Just as a shepherd cares for his flock, providing for their needs and protecting them from danger, so God cares for us. He guides us, comforts us, and assures us of His eternal presence. It is a psalm of deep trust and confidence in the goodness of God.

Question 1

What is the chief end of man? Answer: Man's chief end is to glorify God, and to enjoy him forever. This first question of the Westminster Shorter Catechism sets the foundation for a reformed understanding of human purpose. It teaches that we exist not for our own self-gratification or worldly success, but to reflect the glory of our Creator. To glorify God involves acknowledging His sovereignty, obeying His commandments, and worshiping Him in spirit and in truth. But the answer doesn't stop there; it adds that we are to 'enjoy him forever.' This means that our relationship with God is not meant to be a dry, dutiful burden, but a source of profound joy and satisfaction. As John Piper has famously said, 'God is most glorified in us when we are most satisfied in Him.' This dual purpose of glorifying and enjoying God gives meaning and direction to every aspect of our lives.

Homily IV: On Patience

Saint John Chrysostom. 'I speak not these things to shame you, but as my beloved sons I warn you.' 1 Corinthians 4:14. Paul does not say, 'I speak this to prove you,' nor 'to condemn you,' nor 'to confound you,' but 'to warn you.' And the naming of 'son' is a sufficient ground for forgiveness. For the father, though he be sharper than any other in his reproofs, desires not to punish, but to correct. So also he calls them 'beloved,' which represents the greatest love. For not simply 'sons,' but 'beloved' sons. For it is possible to have sons, and not to love them. But he joins both together. This Homily focuses on the virtue of patience in the face of correction. Chrysostom argues that true correction stems from love, akin to a father's love for his children.

Sermon 5: On the Mount

And seeing the multitudes, he went up into a mountain: and when he was set, his disciples came unto him. And he opened his mouth, and taught them, saying, Blessed are the poor in spirit: for theirs is the kingdom of heaven. Blessed are they that mourn: for they shall be comforted. Blessed are the meek: for they shall inherit the earth. Blessed are they which do hunger and thirst after righteousness: for they shall be filled. Blessed are the merciful: for they shall obtain mercy. Blessed are the pure in heart: for they shall see God. Blessed are the peacemakers: for they shall be called the children of God. Blessed are they which are persecuted for righteousness' sake: for theirs is the kingdom of heaven. Blessed are ye, when men shall revile you, and persecute you, and shall say all manner of evil against you falsely, for my sake. Rejoice, and be exceeding glad: for great is your reward in heaven: for so persecuted they the prophets which were before you. This opening section of the Sermon on the Mount, known as the Beatitudes, describes the character and blessedness of the citizens of God's kingdom.